

Passages - The Prince

Colonies are cheap, more loyal, provoke less hostility among your new subjects, and, as I've said, those few who are provoked can't fight back since they'll be dispossessed refugees.

You must either pamper people or destroy them; harm them just a little and they'll hit back; harm them seriously and they won't be able to. So if you're going to do people harm, make sure you needn't worry about their reaction.

Seen in advance, trouble is easily dealt with; wait until it's on top of you and your reaction will come too late, the malaise is already irreversible.

To help another ruler to grow powerful is to prepare your own ruin; because it takes flair or military strength to build up a new power, and both will seem threatening to the person who has benefited from them.

Fortune varies but men go on regardless. When their approach suits the times they're successful, and when it doesn't they're not. My opinion on the matter is this: it's better to be impulsive than cautious; fortune is female and if you want to stay on top of her you have to slap and thrust.

You'll see she's more likely to yield that way than to men who go about her coldly. And being a woman she likes her men young, because they're not so cagey, they're wilder and more daring when they master her.

God has shown us amazing,

unprecedented signs: The rest is up to you. God doesn't like doing everything himself, he doesn't want to deprive us of our free will and our share of glory.

The only way to guard against flattery is to have people understand that you don't mind them telling you the truth. But when anyone and everyone can tell you the truth, you lose respect.

A ruler must always take advice, but only when he wants it, not when others want to give it to him. In fact he should discourage people from giving him advice unasked. On the other hand he should ask a great deal and listen patiently when an adviser responds truthfully. And if he realizes someone is keeping quiet out of fear, he should show his irritation.

Men will always be out to trick you unless you force them to be honest.

A ruler isn't smart because he's getting proper advice; on the contrary, it's his good sense that makes the right advice possible.

A ruler's choice of ministers is an important matter. The quality of the ministers will reflect his good sense or lack of it and give people their first impression of the way the ruler's mind is working. If his ministers are capable and loyal, people will always reckon a ruler astute, because he was able to recognize their ability and command their loyalty. When they are not, people will always have reason to criticize, because the first mistake the ruler made was in his choice of ministers.

There are actually three kinds of mind: one kind grasps things unaided, the second

sees what another has grasped, the third grasps nothing and sees nothing. The first kind is extremely valuable, the second valuable, the third useless.

Nothing wins a ruler respect like great military victories and a display of remarkable personal qualities.

With regard to this invitation to remain neutral, nothing could be more damaging to your interests: you'll get no thanks, no consideration and will be taken as a reward by whoever wins.' The contender who is not your ally will always try to get you to stay neutral and your ally will always try to get you to fight. Indecisive rulers who want to avoid immediate danger usually decide to stay neutral, and usually things end badly for them.

A ruler must never ally himself with someone more powerful in order to attack his enemies, unless, as I said above, it is absolutely necessary. Because when you win you'll be at your ally's mercy, and whenever possible rulers must avoid placing themselves in another's power.

So, as I said, a new ruler in a newly constituted state has always armed his subjects.

But when a ruler acquires a new territory to add like an extra limb to an existing state, then he must disarm its people, except for the men who supported him when he took it. But with time and opportunity even those men should be kept weak and emasculated so that all the real armed force in the state as a whole resides with your own soldiers who live with you in your home base.

When destiny wants to make a ruler great,

particularly a new ruler who, unlike a hereditary king, really needs to build up his reputation, it sends him enemies and prompts them to attack him. That way he has the chance to beat them and climb the ladder his enemies have put in front of him. Hence many people reckon that when the opportunity presents itself a smart ruler will shrewdly provoke hostility. so that he can then increase his reputation by crushing it.

Everyone will appreciate how admirable it is for a ruler to keep his word and be honest rather than deceitful. However outwitting opponents with their cunning, these men achieved more than leaders who behaved honestly.

There are two ways of doing battle: using the law and using force. Typically, humans use laws and animals force. But since playing by the law often proves inadequate, it makes sense to resort to force as well. Hence a ruler must be able to exploit both the man and the beast in himself to the full.

A sensible leader cannot and must not keep his word if by doing so he puts himself at risk, and if the reasons that made him give his word in the first place are no longer valid.

People are so gullible and so caught up with immediate concerns that a con man will always find someone ready to be conned.

People decide for themselves whether to love a ruler or not, while it's the ruler who decides whether they're going to fear him, a sensible man will base his power on what he controls, not on what others have

freedom to choose. But he must take care, as I said, that people don't come to hate him.

Is it better to be loved rather than feared, or vice versa? The answer is that one would prefer to be both but, since they don't go together easily, if you have to choose, it's much safer to be feared than loved. We can say this of most people: that they are ungrateful and unreliable; they lie, they fake, they're greedy for cash and they melt away in the face of danger. So long as you're generous and, as I said before, not in immediate danger, they're all on your side: they'd shed their blood for you, they'd give you their belongings, their lives, their children. But when you need them they turn their backs on you. The ruler who has relied entirely on their promises and taken no other precautions is lost. Friendship that comes at a price, and not because people admire your spirit and achievements, may indeed have been paid for, but that doesn't mean you really possess it and you certainly won't be able to count on it when you need it.

A man will sooner forget the death of his father than the loss of his inheritance.

Since a ruler can't be generous and show it without putting himself at risk, if he's sensible he won't mind getting a reputation for meanness.

For the ruler already in power generosity is dangerous; for the man seeking power it is essential.

If a ruler wants to survive, he'll have to learn to stop being good, at least when the occasion demands.

One of the many negative consequences of not having an army is that people will find you pathetic, and this is a stigma a ruler must guard against, as I'll explain. The fact is that between a man who has an army and a man who hasn't there is simply no comparison. And there is no reason why a man who commands an armed force should willingly obey a man who doesn't, or why a man who doesn't command an army should live safely beside a servant who does.

A sensible leader must follow this advice and never relax in peacetime but work hard to make the most of it and turn it to his advantage in the tough times ahead. That way, when his luck does turn, he'll be ready.

There is nothing so weak and unstable as a reputation for power that is not backed up by its own army.

It's human nature to tie yourself to a leader as much for the services you've done him as the good he's done you.